PSYC100: General Psychology

Week 2: The Psychology Behind Professional Success

Milestone 1: Intrinsic Nutrients & Cognitive Bandwidth

Professional execution relies heavily on maximizing baseline cognitive bandwidth. When an individual's core psychological needs are starved, a severe bandwidth tax diminishes working memory, misdirects critical focus, and reduces performance to a survival mechanism.

Lesson 1: Maslow’s Hierarchy & The Bandwidth Tax

Abraham Maslow's hierarchical framework establishes that human motivation is structured sequentially. If lower-level foundational needs are compromised, an individual experiences a severe cognitive resource drain, dragging focus down from high-level problem-solving.

■ Expanded Content: Structural Workplace Needs Alignment

- **Physiological Needs:** Fundamental requirements including functional rest, proper nutrition, and ergonomic stability.
- **Safety & Security:** Clear structural expectations, predictable environment parameters, and reliable tooling.
- **Belongingness (Social):** Direct peer inclusion, shared group environments, and active communication networks.
- **Esteem Metrics:** Tangible recognition, validated technical respect, and actionable feedback loops.
- **Self-Actualization:** The unrestricted pursuit of mastery, systemic innovation, and full creative capabilities.

```
# Simulation: Cognitive Bandwidth Allocation & Resource Drain
def compute_available_ram(unmet_needs_count):
    baseline_ram = 100
    bandwidth_tax = unmet_needs_count * 20
    available_bandwidth = max(0, baseline_ram - bandwidth_tax)
    return f"Available Cognitive RAM: {available_bandwidth}%"
```

Lesson 2: Self-Determination Theory & Motivation Nutrients

Self-Determination Theory (Deci & Ryan, 1985) proves that sustainable baseline drive relies on intrinsic motivation rather than external bribes or fear mechanics.

■ Expanded Content: The Three Core Motivation Nutrients

- **Autonomy:** The explicit verification that an individual possesses meaningful choice over execution methods.
- **Competence:** The psychological feeling of mastery supported by specific, actionable progress feedback.
- **Relatedness:** Systemic validation of how an individual's efforts connect directly to a larger team purpose.

Milestone 2: Structural Targeting & Efficiency Drivers

Setting high-impact performance targets requires transforming ambiguous demands into challenging, highly specific operational parameters.

Lesson 3: Locke & Latham's Goal-Setting Optimization

Vague instructions scatter human effort. Locke & Latham's Goal-Setting Theory demonstrates that specific, difficult targets systematically maximize performance output by focusing action and defining exact completion criteria.

```
# SMART Framework Validator Model
def generate_smart_goal(metric, baseline, target_value, deadline):
    return {
        "Specificity": f"Optimize {metric} from {baseline} to {target_value}",
        "Measurability": "Tracked daily via automated analytics dashboards",
        "Time_Bound": f"Hard execution ceiling locked to: {deadline}"
    }
```

Lessons 4 & 5: Self-Efficacy Elements & Mindset Re-Framing

Albert Bandura (1977) defines self-efficacy as an individual's task-specific belief in their capability to execute a path. This is reinforced through intentional reframing, shifting self-talk from static evaluation to clear process management.

■ **Expanded Content: Bandura's Four Efficacy Accelerators**

1. Mastery Experiences: Securing a string of small, indisputable task successes to build empirical proof.
2. Vicarious Modeling: Intentionally shadowing and observing similar peers navigate identical complexities successfully.
3. Verbal Persuasion: Reviewing objective, highly credible feedback from trusted technical mentors.
4. Physiological Regulation: Employing deliberate tactical breathing and cognitive reframing to control stress cues.

Milestone 3: Systemic Resilience & Intervention Matrices

True occupational endurance requires dividing complex psychological stressors into objective, trackable variables and applying targeted behavioral changes.

Lessons 6–13: Locus of Control, Flow, and Cognitive Re-Attribution

Resilience relies on shifting energy from external concerns toward internal controls, matching situational challenges to current skill metrics, and fact-checking negative mental loops.

Framework Context	Core Psychological Objective	Targeted Remediation Action

Locus of Control	Shift perspective from External to Internal	Isolate Control/Influence circles; stop wasting energy on raw concerns.
Flow Theory	Align Task Challenge perfectly to Skill Metric	Protect 90-minute focus blocks; turn off notifications to stop context switching.
ABCDE REBT Model	Dispute irrational, automatic beliefs	Separate the event (A) from the belief (B) using objective fact checks (D).
Imposter Syndrome	Correct fraudulent skill attribution defects	Run concrete evidence reviews; use peer disclosure to normalize pressure.
Psychological Safety	Lower interpersonal risk boundaries	Leads explicitly model vulnerability; welcome candor instead of forced agreement.

```
# Cognitive Re-Attribution Routine (Clance & Imes / Ellis Synthesis)
def process_automatic_thought(activating_event, automatic_belief, empirical_evidence):
    if automatic_belief == "Luck got me here" and len(empirical_evidence) > 0:
        return f"Disputation Triggered: Driven by skills: {empirical_evidence}"
    return "Re-evaluating internal attribution metrics..."
```